

Paralympic gold in 2016 changed the way women were perceived, says Deepa Malik

During a panel discussion titled 'Empowering the Game – Unleashing Women's Potential in Sports' at the Sportstar Focus Bihar Conclave, Rio Paralympics silver medallist Deepa Malik said that her momentous feat at the 2016 Games changed the way women were perceived in para sport.

"There has been a huge change in mindset. It took one medal at the Rio Paralympics to create that ripple effect, which gave belief," Malik, who clinched silver in the women's shot put F53 event, said. "I would thank the Honourable Prime Minister because once we won that medal, there was a lot of respect given to me and a lot of awards bestowed upon me. Post that medal in Rio, we not only had parents but also husbands coming with their wives, children bringing their mothers to come out and play in disability. We need to create more role models and that will encourage more and more women... 2016 had the first female medal, but with Tokyo and Paris, we have 14 more female Paralympic medals."

However, there are still barriers for women who want to play sport in the country, and communication and awareness remain key in removing those barriers.

"A lot of our athletes suffer from very low haemoglobin levels. You mix that up with heavy bleeding, and that is going to be catastrophic. The nutrition level of our athletes is a big problem. Grassroots athletes are also not aware of options such as period underwear."

"There are a lot of misconceptions around contraception. The athletes know very little about their bodies and are not able to have a confident conversation with their coaches. They don't know that period can have an impact on performance," Aditi Mutatkar, Program Head, Athlete and Women Initiatives at Simply Sport Foundation, said.

Mihira Khopkar, a sports nutritionist who works with Reliance Foundation Hospital, echoed Aditi's views.

"Out of the 500 athletes we surveyed, 70 per cent said they find themselves in a very uncomfortable spot to speak about menstruation to their male coaches. Without having these conversations, there is no way ahead. The onus is on the coaches to make the athletes more comfortable, for which the coaches, parents and support system need to be empowered and educated for them to have the comfort to talk about it. Communication continues to be a huge barrier," Mihira said.



From right: Deepa Malik (Paralympic Medallist), Aditi Mutatkar (Prog Head Athlete and Women Initiatives, Simply Sport Foundation), and Mihira Khopkar (Sports Nutritionist) in conversation with Lavanya Lakshmi Narayanan during the Conclave. R. V. MOORTHY